

INTERNAL BUSINESS INTELLIGENCE TASK ASSIGNMENT

SuperStore Sales Performance and Profitability Review

Assigned by: Head of Data Analytics

Assigned to: Junior Data Analyst / Business Intelligence Analyst

Task Assignment Memo

Hi Team,

I am assigning you a new business intelligence project using the attached SuperStore Sales Dataset.

The dataset contains 5,901 sales transaction records and includes information such as order details, customer segment, region, product category, sales, quantity, profit, returns, and payment mode.

Key Columns in the Dataset

Column	Column	Column	Column
Order ID	Order Date	Ship Date	Ship Mode
Customer ID	Customer Name	Segment	Country
City	State	Region	Product ID
Category	Sub-Category	Product Name	Sales
Quantity	Profit	Returns	Payment Mode

Project Background

Over the last few reporting periods, SuperStore has continued to generate sales across multiple regions, customer segments, and product categories. On the surface, the business appears to be performing well because sales volume is strong.

However, senior management has raised concerns that high sales may not always be translating into strong profit.

We need to understand whether the business is growing profitably or whether some products, regions, customer groups, or operational activities are reducing overall performance.

There are also concerns around returns, shipping methods, and product-level profitability. Some areas of the business may be generating revenue but contributing little or no profit. In some cases, certain products or locations may even be creating losses.

Management needs a clear, evidence-based analysis before making decisions on sales strategy, product focus, regional investment, pricing, operations, and marketing.

Your Role

You are acting as a Junior Data Analyst / Business Intelligence Analyst within the Data Analytics team.

Your task is to analyse the SuperStore sales data and produce an Excel-based business intelligence dashboard that helps management understand the true performance of the business.

You are expected to work like an analyst in a real business environment. This means you should not only create charts, but also explain what the charts mean and what actions management should consider.

Main Business Problem

Management wants to answer this question: Where is SuperStore making money, where is it losing money, and what should the business do to improve profitability?

Your analysis should help management identify strong and weak regions, profitable and unprofitable products, high-performing and low-performing categories, valuable customer segments, products or areas affected by returns, shipping modes that may affect operational performance, and business areas where high sales are not producing enough profit.

Main Objective

Your main objective is to build a professional Excel dashboard and insight report that will help senior management make better commercial decisions.

The dashboard should show not only sales performance, but also profitability performance.

A product, state, region, or category should not be considered successful only because it has high sales. You must also check whether it is generating profit.

Key Business Questions You Must Answer

1. Executive Performance

1. What is the total sales value?
2. What is the total profit?
3. What is the total quantity sold?
4. How many orders are in the dataset?
5. What is the overall profit margin?
6. What is the total number of returned orders?
7. What is the average sales value per order?

2. Regional Performance

8. Which region generated the highest sales?
9. Which region generated the highest profit?
10. Are there any regions with strong sales but weak profit?
11. Which state generated the highest sales?
12. Which state generated the highest profit?
13. Which states are generating losses or very low profit?
14. Which cities are the strongest contributors to sales and profit?
15. Which cities should management investigate because of poor profitability?

3. Product and Category Performance

16. Which product category generated the highest sales?
17. Which product category generated the highest profit?
18. Which sub-category generated the highest sales?
19. Which sub-category generated the highest profit?
20. Which sub-categories are producing low or negative profit?
21. What are the top 10 products by sales?
22. What are the top 10 products by profit?
23. What are the bottom 10 products by profit?
24. Are there any products with high sales but low or negative profit?
25. Which products should be reviewed for pricing, discounting, or removal?

4. Customer Segment Analysis

26. Which customer segment generated the highest sales?
27. Which customer segment generated the highest profit?
28. Does the segment with the highest sales also generate the highest profit?
29. Which segment has the highest average order value?
30. Which customer segment should the business prioritise for growth?

5. Shipping and Operations Analysis

31. Which shipping mode is used most often?
32. Which shipping mode generates the highest sales?
33. Which shipping mode generates the highest profit?
34. What is the average number of days between order date and ship date?
35. Which shipping mode has the fastest average shipping time?
36. Are any shipping modes linked with lower profitability?

6. Returns Analysis

37. How many orders were returned?
38. Which product category has the highest number of returns?
39. Which sub-category has the highest number of returns?
40. Which region has the highest number of returns?
41. Are returned orders affecting profit?
42. Which products or categories should be reviewed because of return patterns?

7. Payment Mode Analysis

43. Which payment mode is most commonly used?
44. Which payment mode generates the highest sales?
45. Which payment mode generates the highest profit?
46. Are there any noticeable differences in sales or profit by payment mode?

Required Calculated Columns

You must create additional columns to support your analysis. Each calculated column should be explained in the Insight Summary or workbook notes.

Calculated Column	Formula	Business Purpose
Shipping Days	=[@[Ship Date]]-[@[Order Date]]	Shows how many days it took to ship each order and supports shipping performance analysis.
Profit Margin	=[@Profit]/[@Sales]	Shows how much profit is

		retained from sales. Format this as a percentage.
Order Month	=TEXT([@[Order Date]],"mmm")	Supports monthly sales and profit analysis.
Order Year	=YEAR([@[Order Date]])	Supports yearly performance analysis.
Profit Status	=IF([@Profit]<0,"Loss","Profit")	Separates profitable and loss-making orders.
Return Status	=IF([@Returns]="","Not Returned","Returned")	Identifies whether an order was returned. Adjust after inspecting the Returns column.

Required Dashboard

Create an Excel dashboard titled: SuperStore Sales Performance and Profitability Dashboard.

The dashboard should be clear enough for a senior manager to understand without needing you to explain every detail.

Required KPI Cards

- Total Sales
- Total Profit
- Profit Margin
- Total Orders
- Total Quantity Sold
- Total Returns
- Average Order Value

Required Charts

Chart	Purpose	Recommended Visual
Sales by Region	Shows which region generates the most revenue.	Bar chart or column chart
Profit by Region	Shows which region contributes most to profit.	Bar chart or column chart
Monthly Sales Trend	Shows whether sales are increasing or decreasing over time.	Line chart
Monthly Profit Trend	Compares profit movement over time against sales movement.	Line chart
Sales and Profit by Category	Compares revenue and profit across product categories.	Clustered column chart
Top 10 Products by Sales	Identifies the products generating the most revenue.	Horizontal bar chart
Bottom 10 Products by Profit	Identifies products that are damaging profitability.	Horizontal bar chart
Returns by Category or Region	Identifies where returns are concentrated.	Column chart
Average Shipping Days by Ship Mode	Compares delivery speed across shipping methods.	Bar chart

Required Slicers and Timeline

Your dashboard must include slicers for:

- Region
- Category
- Segment
- Ship Mode
- Payment Mode
- Profit Status
- Return Status

You should also add a timeline using Order Date.

Required Workbook Structure

Sheet Name	Purpose
Raw Data	Contains the original dataset.
Cleaned Data	Contains the cleaned and prepared dataset with calculated columns.
Analysis	Contains the PivotTables used to build the dashboard.
Dashboard	Contains the final interactive dashboard.
Insight Summary	Contains written findings and recommendations.

Written Insight Summary

In the Insight Summary sheet, write your findings in a business style. Include the sections below.

Executive Summary

Briefly explain what the dashboard shows.

Key Findings

Write at least five key findings based on your analysis.

Business Risks

Identify areas of concern such as products with negative profit, regions with high sales but weak profit, high returns, slow shipping or low-profit customer segments.

Recommendations

Provide at least five recommendations to management. Your recommendations must be based on your analysis.

Expected Deliverables

1. Excel Workbook

- Cleaned dataset
- Calculated columns

- PivotTables
- Interactive dashboard
- Insight summary

2. Dashboard Screenshot

- Export or screenshot the final dashboard.

3. GitHub Repository

- Upload your project to GitHub. Suggested repository name: superstore-sales-profitability-dashboard.

4. README File

- Project title
- Business problem
- Your role
- Dataset description
- Tools used
- Key business questions
- Dashboard screenshot
- Key findings
- Recommendations

Standard Expected

This should be treated as a professional office assignment. Your work should be:

- Clean
- Structured
- Accurate
- Well-formatted
- Easy to understand
- Suitable for a management audience
- Suitable to showcase on GitHub and LinkedIn

Please do not submit only charts. Management needs insights and recommendations, not just visuals.

Final Message from Management

Please prepare this analysis as though it will be reviewed by the Sales Director, Finance Director, Operations Manager, and Head of Business Intelligence.

The expectation is that your dashboard will help the business move from raw sales data to clear decisions.

Focus on the story behind the numbers.

Regards,
Head of Data Analytics